

Keeping Children Closer to Home by Leveraging the Placement Process

Agenda

1 Re-Introduction to APS

2 Drivers of Out-of-County Placement

3 Reducing OOC Placement with Process

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Using state administrative data, we ask very simple questions

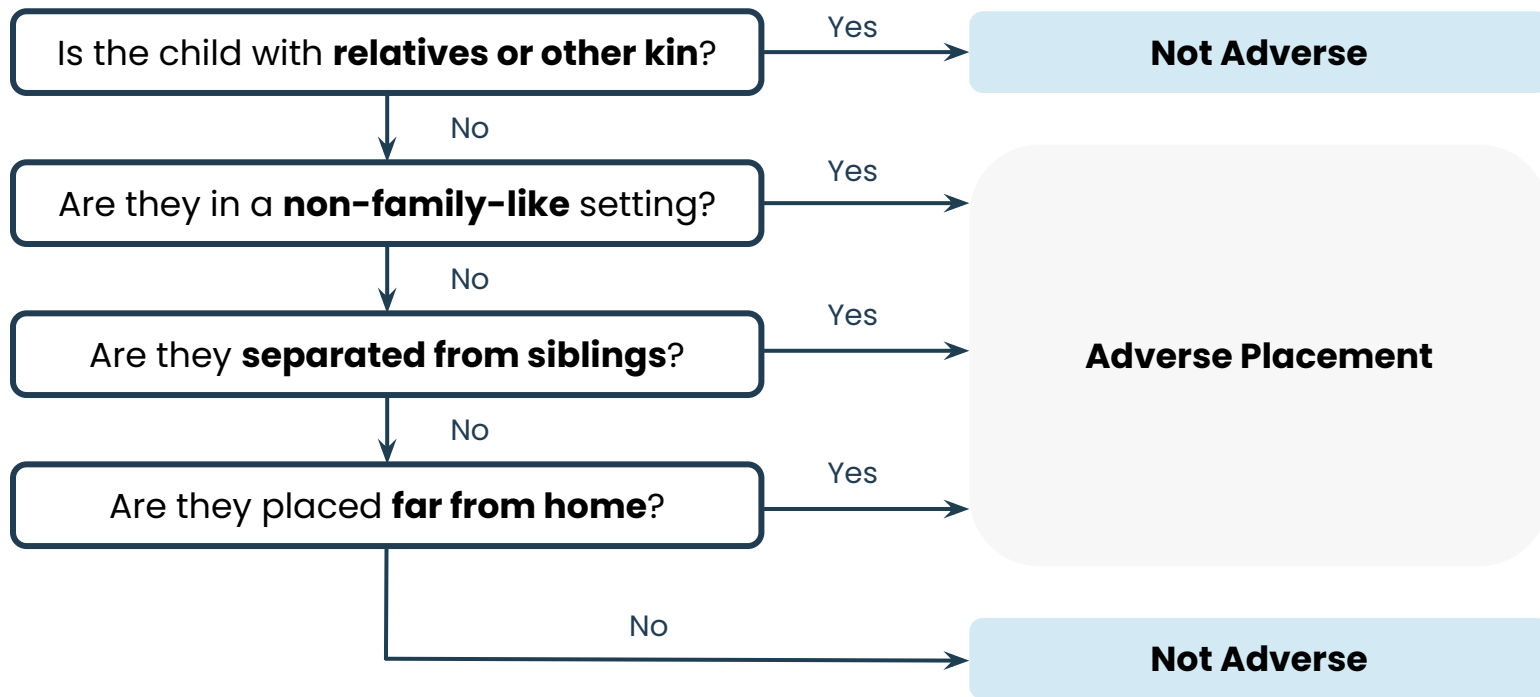
Is the child with **relatives or other kin**?

Are they in a **non-family-like** setting?

Are they **separated from siblings**?

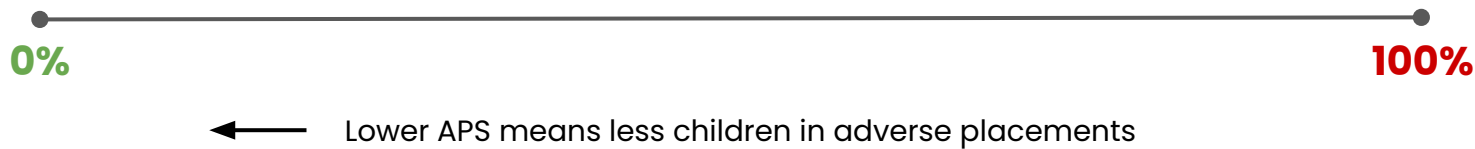
Are they placed **far from home**?

And create a simple metric to target support where gaps exist



Lowering APS aligns strategy with desired outcomes

Adverse Placement Score = % of children in adverse placements



APS can be reduced by **increasing placement with kin or placement in foster homes with siblings, close to home**

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Out-of-county placements are often a significant driver of APS

	APS	% Placed in a Non-Family-Like Setting	% Separated from Siblings	% Placed Out-of-County
Jurisdiction	25%	5%	15%	20%

Out-of-county placements can be particularly problematic



Placed Child & Their Family

- Makes **Family Visits** Harder
- Moves Children from **Schools** and Other Local **Community**



Local Child & Their Family

- **Less Homes** for Local Youth
- Likely Causes **Out-of-County Placements** for Local Youth



Case Worker Drive Time

- Potentially Drives **Lower Case Worker Retention**
- Turnover Can Be **Disruptive**

Out-of-county placements can signal recruitment need

	# of Children Placed <u>Out</u> of This County	# of Children Placed <u>Into</u> This County
County A	100	25

In some counties, we observe many **more children leaving than coming in**, indicating there aren't enough homes to support in-county placement

Other times, capacity exists but is used for out-of-county children

	# of Children Placed <u>Out</u> of This County	# of Children Placed <u>Into</u> This County
County A	100	25
County B	50	50

In some counties, many children went out-of-county while **local homes were used for out-of-county children**, indicating there were potentially enough homes

There are several reasons why this “swapping” might happen

1

Agency Purview

- Agencies may only look to in-agency homes rather than coordinating with other agencies to make the most local placement.
 - Agencies may not receive the information necessary to make the most local placement for the child.
-

2

Placement Process

- State placement processes may not prioritize placement close to home.
 - For example, in a regional placement system, placement workers look for homes within a region, rather than on the county level, which may lead to more out-of-county placements.
-

3

Timing & Preferences

- Available foster homes are filled as children come into care. Waiting for the perfect home to come available is not an option.
- Homes available at the time of placement may only be in other counties or only be willing to take certain types of placements.

Oklahoma designed a new process to support local placement

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One year later, the new process is working where we expected

	# of Children Placed <u>Out</u> of This County	# of Children Placed <u>Into</u> This County	% Change in OOC One Year After New Placement Process
County A	100	25	+2%
County B	50	50	-9%

While counties with foster home shortages still struggle, counties that appeared to have enough homes are now using them better, **keeping children closer to home**

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Background on Oklahoma Child Welfare

State-Run System

- Oklahoma operates a centralized, state-administered child welfare system through Oklahoma Human Services

Centralized Practice

- Policies, procedures, and core practice standards are implemented statewide, creating consistencies and standards across counties and regions.

Public-Private Foster Care Model

- Traditional foster homes may be approved and maintained by OHS or private child placing agencies under contract with the state.

Placement Process Progression in Oklahoma

Decentralized & Inconsistent

- Placement searches handled by **on-call, caseload-carrying staff**
- On-call rotations varied (daily vs. weekly)
- Staff managed placements **in addition to** kinship, foster care, or adoption work
- Limited consistency, communication, and documentation statewide

A horizontal white arrow pointing from left to right, with three vertical tick marks at the positions of the labels Pre-2016, 2016, and 2020.

Pre-2016

2016

2020

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Dedicated Placement Staff

- Pilot introduction of **non-caseload-carrying placement specialists**
- Focused solely on placement searches and disruptions
- Participation in MDT meetings and shelter staffings
- Increased familiarity with youth and foster homes
- Added support for foster parents → **improved foster home retention**

Pre-2016

2016

2020

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Statewide Implementation

- Dedicated placement staff expanded across all regions
- Consistent documentation and coordinated statewide efforts
- Stronger staff collaboration and communication
- Daily statewide collaboration call between specialists and agency partners

Pre-2016

2016

2020

Placement Process Progression in Oklahoma



Unintended Outcomes

- Increased out-of-county placements
- Youth placed farther from families and communities
- Barriers to reunification, sibling connections, and permanency



Specialized Foster Care Roles

Foster care staff were divided statewide into:

- **Kinship-focused staff** (assessment and maintenance)
- **Dedicated placement staff** assigned to traditional foster homes



Placement Process Progression in Oklahoma



Stronger Local Connections

Placement staff began **carrying traditional foster families**, allowing them to:

- Build relationships within their **county of jurisdiction**
- Understand family preferences, strengths, and skill sets
- Engage in open, honest discussions about youth needs



Improved Placement Outcomes

- Increased **in-county placements**
- Better alignment between youth needs and foster family capacity
- Improved continuity and community connections for youth



Thank You!

**Please feel free to reach out:
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Experienced with Foster Care Data

We have spent four years helping child welfare agencies use data to drive better outcomes



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Our work is informed by data and research, and we have access to world-leading experts



Centered on the Child's Experience

We root our analysis in a ground truth: where the child is placed when they are in care



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Foster Insights is a nonprofit dedicated to using data to improve child welfare